energised membership base to even design its election slogans. ‘For the first time, we started asking people what the sloganeering campaign would be. We got 30,000 slogans from all across the country,’ recalls Tikoo, who was part of campaign-organisation meetings.

The party’s 2014 slogan ‘Ab ki baar Modi sarkar’ (this time, Modi government) came from one of these volunteers. ‘It was not [advertising executive] Piyush Pandey, it was not [lyricist and ad executive] Prasoon Joshi, and Prasoon has, I think, openly accepted it also. It was one of the volunteers who wrote about those slogans on the digital platform. So Piyush and Prasoon thought of giving it a final shape. That is how that slogan came.’[104]

When the BJP Wanted to Disband Itself: The Blueprint that Drove the New BJP

It is difficult to imagine now, but there was a time when Atal Bihari Vajpayee, as BJP president, actually thought of disbanding the party. The party, which had imagined itself from Day One as an ‘alternative to Cong (I)’[105] had suffered a crushing defeat in 1984, winning just two parliamentary seats in that year’s national election. Vajpayee, its most popular national leader, had himself lost his parliamentary seat from Gwalior to Congress’s Madhav Rao Scindia. Crestfallen, he commissioned a special twelve-member working group in 1985 to review the party’s functioning and to answer some tough questions on why the BJP found itself ‘miles away’ from its objective after its first five years.[106]

One of these questions was whether the BJP’s creation itself had been a mistake and whether it should dissolve itself and return to its Jan Sangh avatar. In its first two years, as now, the BJP had focused on the nuts and bolts of building an organisation. As a review by L.K. Advani had noted in 1983, the organisation’s aim was ‘almost entirely on enrolling members, forming committees, and thus building the party’s organisational infrastructure right from the Panchayat level to the level of Parliament’.[107] In its first two years, the BJP’s primary membership went from 2.2 million to 3.9 million.